But the gap in perceptions played out in various practical ways. In 1947, for example, US Ambassador to New Delhi Henry Grady proposed American assistance in dam-building in India. To his surprise, Nehru wanted to limit the use of machines in order to employ more manual workers. [34] A few months later, Grady proposed a 'Treaty of Friendship, Navigation, and Commerce' to deepen the economic relationship, but the Indian side did not take him up on the offer. [35] Yet other initiatives did take off, including assistance from the Tennessee Valley Authority in the United States for the establishment of the Damodar Valley Corporation to manage flooding, navigation, irrigation, and electricity generation and transmission in West Bengal and present-day Jharkhand. [36]

Amid this backdrop, Nehru visited the United States in late 1949 to significant fanfare, although it did little to consolidate relations with the Truman administration. Despite some shared concerns about China, and India's attempt to leverage these concerns to receive aid and economic benefits, the US and India initially had different assessments of China's motivations and security environment, Beijing's relation with Moscow, and the role of Pakistan. Despite significant attention, the visit achieved little that was concrete and may even have contributed to mutual disillusionment. [37] The United States also tended in these early years to defer to the United Kingdom on matters related to South Asia and only began to become more wary of London's agenda after 1951. [38] Relations with the United States were not entirely non-cooperative. With the outbreak of the Korean War in 1950—during which a US-led United Nations force backed South Korea against a Chinese- and Soviet-backed North Korea—New Delhi did send a small military medical mission in support of US, UN, and South Korean forces. (An Indian flag still flies in front of the Korean War Memorial in Seoul.) India was also involved in the repatriation of prisoners of war during that conflict. [39] But overall, while India did receive some aid from the United States in the early 1950s, it was far less than Europe, Japan and Taiwan, and less per capita than Pakistan.

In Europe too, India tilted more to the West at first. It was quick to recognize West Germany and refrained from establishing diplomatic